

Instructor Notes – Activity 3: 5-Step Critique Framework

Overview

Purpose: Give participants a simple, reusable **5-step check** for any AI output so they can decide whether to **keep and refine**, **re-prompt in a new direction**, or **start again**.

The 5 steps:

1. **Purpose** – What is this output for, and for whom?
2. **Plausibility** – Does it pass a basic sense check?
3. **Evidence** – How do we know it’s true / appropriate?
4. **Stakes** – What happens if it’s wrong or weak?
5. **Action** – What should we change, keep, or do next?

This activity links directly to the “**human in the loop**” message: AI produces drafts, humans apply judgement.

It is also the place to pick up the **cognitive offloading** / “**is this good for learning?**” concerns you lightly flagged in Activity 1. You can say, for example:

“Earlier we saw how quickly AI can help us draft summaries and announcements. Now we’re asking the harder question: **Is this actually good enough for learning, or are we building cognitive debt by letting the system do too much of the thinking?** The 5-step critique is how we surface those issues and decide what *we* need to change.”

Suggested Flow (15 minutes)

- 2–3 minutes – Explain the 5 steps (slide/handout).
 - 8–9 minutes – Pairs apply the framework to a real AI output from Activities 1–2.
 - 3–4 minutes – Optional AI self-critique demo + bridge to Activity 4.
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Introduce the Framework (2–3 minutes)

Put this on a slide or handout:

- **Purpose** – What job is this text trying to do? Who is it for?
- **Plausibility** – Does anything sound obviously wrong, vague, or oversimplified?
- **Evidence** – Are important claims supported by examples, data, or references?
- **Stakes** – Is this low-stakes (ideas) or high-stakes (assessment, advice)? What happens if it's wrong?
- **Action** – What should I keep, change, or delete? Do I refine, re-prompt, or start again?

You can say:

“You don’t need to memorise the labels – just walk through these five questions in order.”

Optional **student-friendly questions** you can share:

- Purpose: “What is this trying to do?” “Is the tone right for the audience?”
 - Plausibility: “Does it fit with what I already know?”
 - Evidence: “What would I need to check before trusting this?”
 - Stakes: “If this is wrong, who could be misled or harmed?”
 - Action: “What should I change, and what should I do next?”
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Hands-On: Critique One AI Output (8–9 minutes)

Ask participants to work in pairs.

Step 1 – Choose an AI output

- From Activities 1–2:
 - summary, LMS announcement, quiz, rewritten brief, or teaching idea.
- Or another AI output they have on hand.

Step 2 – Apply the 5 steps

On the slide:

1. Choose one AI output you generated earlier.
2. In pairs, apply the 5-step critique:
 - Spend 1–2 minutes per step.
 - Jot down at least one **strength** and one **concern** for each step.
3. Decide together:
 - **Keep and lightly edit?**
 - **Re-prompt in a new direction?**
 - **Discard and start from scratch?**

You can also give them a simple grid on paper:

- Columns: **Purpose** | **Plausibility** | **Evidence** | **Stakes** | **Action**
 - Rows: **Strengths** | **Concerns / Risks** | **What I'll do next**.
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Optional: AI Self-Critique Demo (3–4 minutes)

This is just for your screen, if time allows.

1. Take one volunteer's AI output (with permission).

2. Run a **self-critique prompt**:

Using the following 5-step critique framework:

- 1) Purpose, 2) Plausibility, 3) Evidence, 4) Stakes, 5) Action, critically evaluate the output you just produced.

For each step, briefly comment on:

- Strengths of the output
- Limitations or risks
- One concrete suggestion to improve it for use with university students in [discipline].

3. Ask the room:

- “What did it notice that you also saw?”
- “What did *you* see that it missed?”
- “Would you trust it to do the critique for you?”

You can summarise:

“Even critique can be co-piloted, but not outsourced. This framework is really for *you* – to decide whether to keep and refine, change direction, or start again.”

Links to Other Activities

- **From Activities 1–2:** The AI outputs they produced (summaries, announcements, quizzes, redesigned prompts) are exactly what they now **critique**.
- **To Activity 4 (Assessment Stress-Test):** The same mindset scales up:
 - Instead of critiquing a short output, they’ll stress-test **whole assessments**:
 - * Can AI do this task?
 - * How plausible is its response?
 - * What are the stakes?
 - * What actions should we take in redesign?

Use this line to bridge:

“We’ve used the 5 steps on low-stakes outputs: summaries, announcements, quiz questions. Next we’ll use similar thinking on **whole assessments**: if AI can do this task easily, what does that mean for how we design it?”